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A multi-level model of family enterprise corruption

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ABSTRACT

Corruption is an important social and economic problem globally, and family firms are an important source of such corruption that we know too little about. By leveraging insights from the literature on family priorities, governance, and institutional environments, we develop a multi-level model highlighting why some family firms are prone to exhibit corruption in specific contexts. We focus on businesses where close connections between firm and family cause the priorities of the one to affect the other. There, family loyalties, conflicts, ethics, and social aspirations can enhance the willingness to engage in corrupt behavior. Private ownership and secrecy facilitate that behavior, as do tempting contexts with few institutional constraints. We provide examples and propositions for further research.

> "Corruption is not a new phenomenon. Two thousand years ago, Kautilya, the prime minister of an Indian king, had already written a book, Arthashastra, discussing it. Seven centuries ago, Dante placed bribers in the deepest parts of Hell, reflecting the medieval distaste for corrupt behavior. Shakespeare gave corruption a prominent role in some of his plays; and the American Constitution made bribery one of two explicitly-mentioned crimes which could lead to the impeachment of a U.S. president." (Tanzi, 1998: 559–560).

Corruption remains a major problem around the world, where according to Transparency International, at least six billion people live in corrupt countries, which the World Economic Forum claimed cost the global economy $3.6 trillion dollars annually (Johnson, 2018). As the most common type of company globally accounting for most employment (Pieper, Kellermanns, & Astrachan, 2021), family firms play an important role in participating in such corruption.

Notorious examples of family firm corruption abound in the popular press. These include the Sackler family's contribution to the opioid epidemic via hyper-aggressive marketing and illegal kickbacks by their company Purdue Pharma (Randles, 2021), securities fraud by the Rigas family at Adelphia (SEC, 2002), bribery of a government official by a member of the Lee family, owners of Samsung (BBC, 2021), and accounting fraud by the Tanzi's at Parmalat (e.g. Dagnino, Minà, & Picone, 2013), just to mention some of the better-known cases. Equally scandalous incidences of corruption were perpetrated by family firms during the Covid-19 pandemic, as highlighted, for example, in a *New York Times* article on several Latin American companies that overcharged desperate hospitals for faulty goods and equipment that endangered the lives of patients (Kitroff & Taj, 2020). Unfortunately, to date, there has been little research on the topic (Eddleston & Mulki, 2021). In this essay we attempt to build a multi-level model of family firm corruption, suggesting some primary drivers and facilitators to anchor subsequent research efforts.

1. A contentious literature

Where they behave well, family firms produce economic and social benefits, promote economic growth and modernization, and may sometimes combat corruption (Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2020; Memili, Fang, Chrisman, & De Massis, 2015). Where they behave badly, they have an opposite effect, constraining competition, hobbling local economies, and exploiting stakeholders and the natural environment (Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2022; Morck & Yeung, 2004; Smith, 2023; Song, Jun, & Ma, 2021). This is especially problematic in developing economies vulnerable to and conducive of corrupt business practices and prime venues of family wealth and family firm presence as well as economic and political influence (Caroli, Pongelli, & Valentino, 2020; Hamid, 2014).

Unfortunately, research on family firm corruption remains at an early stage (Eddleston & Mulki, 2021). Although some informative studies exist, most are based on individual examples (e.g., Hamid, 2014), region-specific (e.g., Song et al., 2021), or type of corruption-specific (e.g. Temouri, Nardella, Jones, & Brammer, 2022).

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Thus, there is disagreement as to when and whether family businesses are more corrupt than others, with studies such as Amore and Marzano (2022), Ding, Qu, and Wu (2016), Ding and Wu (2014), Kuo (2022), Martin, Campbell, and Gómez-Mejía (2016), Rondi, Benedetti, Bettinelli, and De Massis (2023), Smulowitz, Cossin, De Massis, and Lu (2023) and Temouri *et al.* (2022) maintaining that family firms engage less in corruption, while Krishnan and Peytcheva (2019) and Medioli, Marchini, and Mazza (2023) suggest the opposite, and Jiang and Min (2023) present a mixed and contingent picture (see also the review by Vazquez, 2018). Perhaps these disagreements are due in part to the lack of a general conceptual perspective for why and when family firm owners and leaders are most likely to engage in corrupt behavior. Thus, it is not a question of whether family firms are more corrupt, but of which specific family- and family firm related conditions and circumstances facilitate corrupt behavior. That is our topic.

2. Our scope

We define corrupt behavior as *occurring when those in power seek benefit by exploiting unethically or illegally firm stakeholders or society*. According to Boyd (1987: 59): "Corruption occurs when individuals or groups, for their own benefit, violate codes of conduct or standards of behavior that they profess, or are expected, to uphold." Although what is considered corrupt varies across cultures, and its boundaries can be debated, in general corruption involves a person or small group with influence harmfully exploiting a frequently larger, less influential group (DiRienzo, Das, Cort, & Burbridge, 2007). In the process, laws or ethical norms are violated and public resources or well-being are degraded (Waldman, 1974). The magnitude of corruption varies from minor misdeeds to grand systemic breaches. Included are bribery, restraint of trade and collusion, tax evasion, pernicious cronyism or malignant nepotism, and impactful dishonesty. Lobbying to obtain unfair privilege from authorities, giving kickbacks to politicians, and avoiding legal compliance are typical corruption mechanisms (Akindele, 2005; Eddleston & Mulki, 2021; Khelil & Khlif, 2023; Klein, Holmes Jr, Foss, Terjesen, & Pepe, 2022).

Our topic is *family firm* corruption – that which is motivated by family ethics, needs and desires and enacted by family owners or family firm executives *for the parochial benefit of family members* (Banfield, 1958). We thus exclude from the scope of our discussion corrupt behavior that family firm members may engage in selflessly and without expectation of reward to help a broader constituency such as a community or social or ethnic group. Our analysis will incorporate drivers of corruption at the family, governance, and institutional levels.

3. A multi-level model of corruption

We believe that specific familial emotional and socioeconomic pressures can induce a *willingness* to be corrupt, while aspects of corporate governance enhance the *ability* to engage in corruption, and the institutional context can increase both that ability and willingness. By leveraging insights from socioemotional, institutional, and corruption literatures (e.g., Castro, Phillips, & Ansari, 2020; De Graaf, 2007; Gómez-Mejía, Cruz, Berrone, & De Castro, 2011; Nyberg, 2021; Rodriguez, Siegel, Hillman, & Eden, 2006), we develop a multi-level model of family firm corruption, proposing familial, governance, and contextual drivers that propose whether, why, and when it occurs. These familial, governance and contextual drivers may compound, thereby acting as a configuration. For example, corrupt family motivations can be more readily put into practice when family actors have ample power and discretion, and where the economic, political, and legal environments are tempting and rewarding breeding grounds for corrupt behavior. Thus, corruption will be especially likely to occur when all drivers are present: constituting a "perfect storm".

Following an expectancy model of motivation (Vroom, 1964; Vroom, Porter, & Lawler, 2015), a) *familial drivers* can be seen as the initial impulse or willingness to engage in corrupt behavior to gain a reward, for example to protect or enrich family members, b) the *power and secrecy* of the family actors represents the ability to pursue that reward, and c) the external *institutional context* influences the likelihood and size of the reward from such behavior, for example, through a hospitable legal or political environment, which can further enhance both the willingness and ability to be corrupt. However, we caution that in contrast to the expectancy model, the model we propose is additive, not multiplicative. That is, although the positive effects on corruption of one driver will be enhanced by the others, each driver by itself will increase the chances of corruption – even in the absence of the others.[1]

The balance of the manuscript is structured around drivers of family firm corruption corresponding to three levels of analysis – familial priorities, firm governance conditions, and institutional contextual forces. We generate propositions and highlight the compounding effects of these drivers before concluding with limitations and suggestions.

4. Familial drivers of corruption

Although many types of social groups channel the behavior of their members, families are unique in having a predominant socializing influence in the early years of life and being the group that typically is most influential in forming values and eliciting loyalty and mimetic behavior (e.g., Grotevant & Cooper, 1985). As a result, the cohesiveness and socio-emotional impact of families are potent in shaping the behavior of their members, ethically and otherwise, within and outside a family business. Where multiple family members own and manage the same business, the problems of the business can impact family dynamics. Thus, business losses can cause mutual blame and conflict among family members. Similarly, family pressures, needs, status priorities, and ethics can tempt and motivate corrupt business behavior. Unlike other types of organizations, this close connection between family problems and dynamics and those of the business overlap, for better or worse. In the latter case, corruption can result.[2]

Therefore when family members work together in a business they own, personal, familial, and commercial challenges intersect, such that family ethics, loyalties, conflicts, and aspirations influence the business; conversely, problems in the business impact the family (Banfield, 1958; De Massis, Kotlar, Chua, & Chrisman, 2014). Thus, for example, family emergencies, jealousies or greed may tempt ethical shortcuts. Family motivations include aiding loved ones under threat, resolving family conflicts, preserving intergenerational prestige, and conforming to family culture. Addressing such priorities can tempt corruption. The following priorities are illustrative.

Protecting loved ones under threat is a powerful family emotion. Often, a nuclear family employs multiple relatives who rely on the business for economic and vocational support. When a family employee or other family member falls ill, there can be an onus to use firm financial resources for medical care and support. Family managers may feel under pressure then to do "what's necessary" to protect the family (Banfield, 1958). If the business is the primary source of family jobs and income and there are bills to pay to meet critical domestic needs, the temptation to engage in corruption to support the family can be considerable. Under familial social or economic pressure, it can become a matter of prioritizing loved ones over others, even at ethical cost.

Whereas securing necessities puts pressure on some families, in others, a primary motivation is to ***avoid or quell family conflict*** by

[1] These components evoke aspects of the Fraud Triangle of incentive (motivation), ability (opportunity), and rationalization (context) (Skousen, Smith, & Wright, 2009).

[2] Certainly, corrupt familial behavior is also based in part on idiosyncratic attributes such as personality, ethical upbringing, character, and past experiences (e.g., Fu, Lee, & Kwan, 2017). However, such unique drivers are beyond our theorizing.

catering to familial demands (Gersick, Davis, Hampton, & Lansberg, 1997). Again, emotional bonds among family members can render these demands poignant, such that preserving the respect and affection of loved ones, and buying family peace, may be key motivations in some family firms (Roman & Miller, 2014). There, family dynamics affect the business, and where longstanding frictions prevail among relatives working in the firm, business resources can be strained in the effort to resolve family conflict. Sometimes, that is done by giving jobs or raises to incompetent complaining relatives or providing children with resources from the business to garner their affection (Schulze, Lubatkin, & Dino, 2003). Such demands may be particularly common where jealousies fester among family employees (Eddleston & Kellermanns, 2007; Kets de Vries & Miller, 1984; Kellermanns, Eddleston, & Zellweger, 2012. Concessions to family members can put financial stress on the business, directly through increased costs, or indirectly through incompetent family executives (Bertrand & Schoar, 2006), increasing the pressure to engage in corrupt behavior. Unfairly rewarding incompetent family members versus more deserving employees also can happen, itself a form of stakeholder or shareholder expropriation.

Aspirations to ***preserve intergenerational prestige and status*** too may motivate corruption. These aspirations often pertain to established later generation family firms with a history of success and wealth accumulation. Thus "keeping up with the Joneses", admission to the right social circles, and expensive schools for offspring, may become important sources of ambition or greed (Agarwal, Mikhed, & Scholnick, 2020). Being raised in a wealthy family can pressure later generations to maintain appearances (Ravina, 2019), sometimes by extracting lavish perquisites from a company that cannot afford them. This may be especially common where family expectations of continued wealth are taken for granted, and where later generations of family managers feel an onus to measure up or are merely avaricious. Wealthy families may also spoil their offspring, developing in them a sense of entitlement and thus greedy and abusive behavior. Pressures may also arise from less wealthy family members hoping to maintain lifestyle. Poverty *relative* to a prior generation in the business is for some, a social stigma (Davis & Harveston, 1999), potentially tempting financial misdeeds among those less scrupulous.

Finally, there is social pressure to ***conform to a lax family moral or unethical culture.*** In some business families, questionable ethics are communicated to offspring beginning in childhood (Hamid, 2014). These transfer across generations, continuing through socialization and errant mentorship (McCord, 1991). When family generations work together in the business, ethical standards of the past are brought forward. Deviating from these standards requires family members to admit that their paternal or maternal kin are unethical, which can be both emotionally and socially repulsive (Klein et al., 2022; Smith, 2023; Vazquez, 2018). Thus, corruption continues.

In short, due to the intimate connection between family business and family life, and the strong familial emotional and social bonds in play, family needs, desires, and moral traditions are powerful drivers of firm behavior, at times leading to corrupt practices, especially where resources from the business are required to address pressing family economic, emotional and social needs (Hamid, 2014; Luo & Chung, 2013).

"P1: Corruption by family firms may occur to protect loved ones under threat, address family conflict, preserve eroding prestige or status, and conform to a lax family moral culture."

5. Firm governance drivers of corruption: Power and privacy

Having discussed familial priorities making family firm owners and executives more willing to engage in corrupt behavior, two governance conditions make them *more able* to do so (De Massis et al., 2014): specifically, family decision making power and the scope for secrecy. Corruption is facilitated when family firm owners and executives have absolute *decision-making discretion*, enabling them to act on family wishes, even against the business sense and ethics of others in the firm (Salimath & Orudzheva, 2022). However, where authority must be shared among board members, owners, and multiple executives, it is likely that checks and balances, audits, formal controls, and more responsible voices and actors will discourage corrupt behavior (Chi, Hung, Cheng, & Lieu, 2015). But where powerful family owners and managers dominate, they are freer to behave according to selfish instincts or familial pressures.[3] They are also more credible as powerful and stable partners to corrupt authorities or other parties, for example other businesses or politicians open to bribery or collusion, and who themselves may initiate corruption demands (Salimath & Orudzheva, 2022). In addition, the stability, endurance, and reach often accorded to *multi-generational* family firms make them especially desirable as potent collaborators for corrupt officials, cronies, and businesses (Van Driel, 2000).[4]

P2: Corruption by family firms will be more likely when decision making discretion is centralized in family firm owners or leaders.

Another governance factor is the *secrecy and privacy* with which some family firms can operate, enabling them to engage in conduct they would refrain from were it to become public. Indeed, privacy and secrecy have been signaled as core competitive advantages of private family firms (Miller & Le Breton-Miller, 2005, 2014; Simon, 2009; Vedrine, 2019). This has allowed them to guard proprietary processes and innovations. However, it also can facilitate undetected malfeasance. There are no public shareholders, directors, or investment analysts to blow the whistle (Chi et al., 2015). This ability to maintain secrecy may not only tempt family members to do the wrong thing, it makes them attractive collaborators to officials wishing to keep their joint misdeeds private (Jiang & Min, 2023; Salimath & Orudzheva, 2022). It also renders them ideal partners for building trust with other firms wishing to engage in private but questionable collusive activities (Van Driel, 2000; dela Rama, 2012).

P3: Corruption by family firms will be more likely when executive behavior and firm conduct can be kept private and secret.

6. Contextual drivers of family firm corruption

Whereas familial and governance factors affect the willingness and ability to engage in corruption, so can the context (Castro et al., 2020; De Graff, 2007). Specifically, where private family priorities and pressures dominate, family managers centralize power, and firms operate in secrecy, then some economic, institutional, and legal environments can stimulate corrupt behavior. Although non-family firms also are more corrupt in these environments, the power, wealth, and secrecy of family firms over the long run make them ideal partners for corrupt commercial counterparties (Morck, Wolfenzon, & Yeung, 2005). Moreover, multi-generational stability and inter-family networks and political connections make business families particularly desirable as collaborators for corrupt cronies and authorities (Palepu & Khanna, 1998). Thus, the arguments below apply to environments that are institutionally weak or subject to corruption.

6.1. Oligopolistic settings: Collusion among family firms

The industry environment conveys a sense of "how things are to be done" (Beckert, 1999). Thus, in oligopolistic industries such as mega-construction, collusion with rivals in bidding is common to avoid competition (De Graaf, 2007; McMullan, 1961). In that context, family

[3] Where families employ super-voting shares to control publicly traded firms, they can amplify their power using the resources of outside shareholders (Morck & Yeung, 2004).

[4] Certainly, corruption by lone entrepreneurs is also facilitated by their power and discretion. But our argument is not that family firms are more corrupt than other types of companies, but that certain facilitating conditions make some family firms more corrupt than others of the same breed.

firms may be *especially* attractive to other family firms as collusive partners. Reciprocal discretion, stability, secrecy, and even social connections among business families (sometimes over generations and through marriage) enhance mutual trust in engaging in restrictive trade practices. That behavior is facilitated where firms are longstanding allies or nominal competitors that share the same social circles and networks. Board interlocks, for example, are common among wealthy owners and managers of firms from different families (Bettinazzi, Miller, & Amore, 2020; Cannella Jr, Jones, & Withers, 2015), fostering informal private communications that enable confidential practices of collusion and trade restriction (Kim & Kim, 1997; Van Driel, 2000). Collusive agreements among groups of family firms also are facilitated by longstanding family entrenchment, aligned pecuniary interests, and protection from prosecution due to secretive, private ownership. Van Driel (2000), for example, highlights the importance of inter-family confidentiality and trust among business families in forming collusive groups and agreements in the transportation industry. The same occurs in the large-project construction business where companies, especially family firms, make agreements not to bid against each other (Ameyaw et al., 2017; Melin & Nordqvist, 2007).

P4: Family firms will be especially likely to engage in collusive corruption with other family firms in oligopolistic commercial environments.

6.2. Institutional structural voids: Political corruption

Corruption also occurs between family firms and political and regulatory entities, especially in countries and regions characterized by institutional voids: that is, a lack of effective public enforcement mechanisms, a paucity of trusted democratic institutions, the absence of a free press, and institutional weaknesses in education, social support, and wealth inequality (Bassetti, Dal Maso, & Lattanzi, 2015; Caroli et al., 2020; Khanna & Yafeh, 2007; Mengoli, Pazzaglia, & Sandri, 2020; Rodriguez et al., 2006). Absent a strong set of such widely respected institutions, corruption flourishes. This is doubly true where elections are poorly administered, and corrupt politicians are secure in their positions (Cintra, Cassol, Ribeiro, & de Carvalho, 2018; Khelil & Khlif, 2023).

Again, the discretion, entrenchment, and secrecy of family business actors, as well as their wealth and long tenures in such contexts make them especially *ideal partners in colluding with corrupt political or regulatory officials* (Khanna & Palepu, 2000; Medioli et al., 2023; Palepu & Khanna, 1998; Song et al., 2021). Politicians can be confident that family business owners will maintain privacy, have the authority to act unilaterally, and will be there for the long run. In turn, the lack of an investigative free press, an impoverished and poorly educated workforce, poor legal enforcement, and a populace weak in democratic rights or values, further empower wealthy family business elites, and disenfranchise potentially dissenting voices (Khelil & Khlif, 2023; Krishnan & Peytcheva, 2019, Palepu & Khanna, 1998). Moreover, in such environments, family firms may exert political pressure by funding elections, purchasing media outlets, marrying government officials, and even running for office (Kim & Kim, 1997), establishing "revolving doors" between business family members and government.

P5: Family firms will be especially likely to engage in political corruption in countries subject to institutional voids.

6.2.1. Legal context: Intergenerational dynastic corruption

The economic and political power of business families can persist for decades in societies where taxation, estate, and commercial legislation *enable them to preserve dynastic wealth and thereby leverage their impact.* In civil law as opposed to common law jurisdictions, there is less protection of public investors and more concentration of wealth and power in the hands of wealthy families (Cross, 2007; La Porta, Lopez-de-Silanes, Shleifer, & Vishny, 1998). Such legacy wealth bestows continuity in economic and social status, affording families enduring leverage with community and governmental authorities to exact regulatory and political favors (De Graaf, 2007). It also makes it easier for wealthy families to join forces with influential elites in business, often via inter-marriage, to garner still greater dynastic political influence over industry regulations, competition policy, and legislation (Acquaah, 2012; Khanna & Palepu, 2000; Medioli et al., 2023; Morck & Yeung, 2004; Morck *et al.* 2005 Salimath & Orudzheva, 2022).

Collusive practices also can be especially enduring in family firms due to their emphasis on *long-term continuity* and intergenerational transfer of norms and relationships (Lumpkin & Brigham, 2011). For example, in some paternalistic family firms, the norms and ethics of the founders are perpetuated due their role model status, thereby embedding corruptive practices throughout the family and the firm (Hamid, 2014; DeBacker, Heim, & Tran, 2015). At the same time, corrupt political and corporate counterparties favor continuing to deal with these families given the legacy relationships and trust built up over the years or generations (dela Rama, 2012; Jun, Kim, & Rowley, 2021).

In Korea, some major family-owned Chaebol conglomerates and business groups are known for their dynastic and paternalistic cultures and legacy relationships with corrupt politicians to obtain favored licensing and other commercial and competitive advantages (Albrecht, Turnbull, Zhang, & Skousen, 2010; BBC, 2021; Jun et al., 2021). Here, wealthy family members, often well beyond the founder generation and with ample family backing, have been among the worst offenders perhaps in part due to their longstanding political connections and inherited family social status, connections, and wealth (BBC, 2021).

P6: Corruption by family firms will be perpetuated across generations in legal contexts favoring dynastic wealth.

6.2.1.1. Combination, compounding, configuration. As we noted at the outset, although the familial, governance and contextual drivers are important in themselves, their combination or joint configuration can be especially problematic. Parochial family priorities, power and secrecy in governance, and particular contexts each can induce or facilitate corrupt behavior. However, it is their joint presence that most enhances the prospect of such conduct. Family economic, emotional, and social priorities and pressures may enhance the *willingness* to act corruptly, family governance power and secrecy increases the *ability* to do so, and the contextual environment can contribute to both that willingness and ability (De Massis et al., 2014). For example, even where family members are tempted to engage in corruption, outside shareholders or a closely monitored and democratic political environment with a free press may discourage such behavior as it might simply be too dangerous and costly. But where those same motives are sheltered from the public, institutionally endorsed, and profitable, corruption is very likely to occur. In other words, where the three drivers are present, they can be mutually reinforcing and thus we expect a greater tendency for corruption (see Table 1).

Certainly, there are highly ethical families and family firms that treasure their privacy and accord much authority power to top family executives. Such businesses, even those with family- centric priorities, are unlikely to succumb to the temptations of corruption, perhaps even less so than non-family public firms as family reputation in the community is at stake, and that can be an emotionally compelling reason to maintain honesty and treat stakeholders ethically (Deephouse & Jaskiewicz, 2013; Zellweger & Nason, 2008). In fact, we see evidence of that in the significant environmental and charitable contributions made by many family firms (Campopiano, De Massis, & Chirico, 2014).[5] Religious families, and those with a legacy of community service and social generosity are also less likely to engage in corrupt behavior (e.g. Le Breton-Miller, Miller, Tang, & Xu, 2024; Mensah, 2014), as are families with a history of close ties to the community and a strong moral

[5] Although the Sacklers who contributed to the opioid epidemic made massive charitable contributions, perhaps to camouflage their destructive business practices.

Table 1
Facilitators of family firm corruption.

Facilitators of corruption	Locus and drivers	Examples
Familial Facilitators		
Family emotional and social connection to the business	Parochial family priorities with (un) ethical implications for the business	Susceptibility to corruption driven by family basic needs or wants, achieving family harmony, preserving family socio-economic status, conforming to family immoral or unethical culture
Governance Facilitators		
Family owner and executive discretion	Power to engage in corrupt practices	Entrenched family executives with the power and status to collude with influential authorities
Family secrecy	Ability to keep practices confidential	Corrupt authorities attracted by secrecy prized by family firms
Contextual Facilitators		
Oligopolistic economic environment	Inter-familial trust	Collusion among family firms
Institutional void	Political power	Corrupt relationships with political authorities
Legal context	Dynastic intent and capacity	Corrupt family and political relations perpetuated inter-generationally

tradition (Litina & Varvarigos, 2023; Miller & Le Breton-Miller, 2005).

But where powerful, secretive firm leaders lack ethical values or are pressured to avoid family poverty or conflict, parochial family priorities can be a red flag. That is especially true where there is an institutional void or industry regulation is lax. In that context, corrupt behavior is especially likely, particularly by secretive and powerful family firms colluding with outside parties who benefit from these kinds of arrangements (Khanna & Palepu, 2000; Palepu & Khanna, 1998). In addition, the contextual and institutional factors facilitating corruption often go together. For example, institutional voids often facilitate and may even enforce corrupt industry practices and cultural norms. And where family members grow up in those surroundings, that can shape their moral values and economic motivations, and thereby influence business conduct.

7. Discussion

Although there are multiple studies of family firm corruption most are empirical, focused on individual cases, particular industries, or comparisons of family versus non-family enterprise. Our contribution is different. We have proposed potential sources of corruption in family firms – examining family emotional, social and governance drivers as well as contextual ones, in the process developing an integrative multilevel perspective. Thus, our analysis is broader than earlier treatments in encompassing familial, governance, and contextual aspects; and also more specific in designating the kinds of family firms and situations more likely to result in corrupt behavior.

An important aspect of our model is that family, governance, and context factors interact and "configure" to drive corruption. For example, even a family under emotional or financial pressure will be less apt to engage in corrupt behavior in public firms with shareholder scrutiny, or in developed economies where regulatory and public oversight is strong (Salimath & Orudzheva, 2022). Conversely, even ethically neutral families may be more predisposed towards corruption in societies where it is rewarding and in industries where it is taken for granted (Jiang & Min, 2023). Finally, when the "stars align" – when family centric families operate in private and have power in a society where corruption is rewarded, we have a perfect storm – a situation where corruption reigns and family firms are better able and better equipped to take advantage than most.

Our model could not include idiosyncratic aspects of a firm that could influence its decision to engage in corrupt practices. For example, the personalities, values, kinship relationships, and experiences of family members are all factors not specified here that can have a bearing on the ethicality of family firms. Moreover, our model is intended to apply to firms with family centric priorities, often in private firms mostly run by family members.

8. Avenues for research

A challenge in studying family firm corruption is the privacy and secrecy of many such firms, as well as the highly sensitive nature of the topic. That makes questionnaire and field studies very challenging options. Those hurdles suggest that researchers may be wise to favor either high level macro or fine-grained approaches. Macro level research might leverage government statistics on specific types of corruption or unethical behavior from government sources such as OSHA and the EPA, press releases about lawsuits, public legal or court records, or other secondary sources (e.g., Caroli et al., 2020; Castro et al., 2020; Song et al., 2021). Moreover, there are informative recent studies showing the geographic distribution of family firms around the world, a most thorough one by Aminadav and Papaioannou (2020); there is another study showing family firm concentration across industries (Amit & Villalonga, 2010). This information can be correlated with institutional indicators such as political corruption, national education, a free press, governance practices, and information from the World Value Survey and other public sources to examine macro associations between family firm presence and potential facilitators or indicators of corruption.

At the micro level of analysis, case studies can be performed of prominent companies that have engaged in corrupt behavior, especially where multiple investigative reporters have published relevant documents (e.g., Dagnino et al., 2013). Series of newspaper articles, and interviews with former employees and journalists can be used to develop a chronology of the decisions, events, and parties involved in a case of corruption to yield insights into its familial, governance and contextual drivers and facilitators. Our model suggests some of the drivers that may be considered. Indeed, this broad array of influences makes fine-grained, in-depth case studies promising vehicles for further clarifying the dimensions of family firm corruption. Clearly, this is a domain where painstaking and creative research methodologies are in great demand.

9. Preventing corruption in family firms

Our analysis suggests lessons for diminishing corruption by family firms. First, outsiders on the board of directors, if truly autonomous and carefully chosen, may provide a more ethical stakeholder-friendly perspective that discourages any temptation towards corrupt behavior (Wan-Hussin, 2009). Such directors may moderate leader dominance and reduce secrecy, and thus reduce their potentiating effect on errant corporate conduct. Second, sharing executive power among family members and non-family executives might induce more reflection in decision making, again, surfacing the liabilities associated with corrupt behavior. Third, new strategic initiatives such as internationalization or entry into new markets may cause executives to become aware of and thus consider the interests and reactions of a new group of stakeholders who are more likely to be alienated by corrupt behavior (Soleimanof, Rutherford & Webb, 2018). Fourth, having a new generation come into the company may induce more reflection about firm and family reputation with stakeholders, and therefore discourage actions that might erode such reputation (Deephouse & Jaskiewicz, 2013).

10. Conclusion

Over the years, family conflicts among wealthy family businesses seem to have been over-represented in the media. Scandalous

comportment among "the rich and famous" can be attractive fare for the tabloids, and indeed where large and prominent family firms have engaged in malfeasance, that often has received a good deal of bad press. Although much of this attention was deserved, we should not be led to conclude that non-family businesses are any less subject to corrupt behavior.

Miller and Le Breton-Miller (2021) argued that family firms are subject to extremes. Regarding corruption, these extremes can extend in positive and negative directions: unusually ethical and moral conduct, but sometimes its opposite as well. This is because although concerns can be narrowly family centric, they may also be stakeholder-centric, where care for family reputation and intergenerational stewardship drive exemplary moral conduct towards stakeholders (Le Breton-Miller & Miller, 2022). In addition, even parochial family priorities may promote ethical behavior where these are based on deeply held moral values or concern for the well-being of current and subsequent generations. It is such contrasts and subtleties that are important qualifications to consider in subsequent studies of family firm corruption.

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